LAN 100 Midterm: Revision Notes

Fall 2026 · Key points only

1. Vocabulary from Context (p. 37–43)

Work out an unfamiliar word from its **context** (the words around it). Underline or circle the word, guess a meaning that makes sense, keep reading, and use a dictionary afterwards only if you need a precise definition.

Types of context clues

Clue	How it works	Signal / hint
Definition	The writer defines the word in the sentence.	commas, dashes, *or*, *is*, *means*
Synonym	A word with a similar meaning appears nearby.	*revolve … circle*
Antonym	A word with the opposite meaning shows a contrast.	*but*, *however*, *while*
Example	Examples illustrate what the word means.	*for example*, *such as*
Explanation	The writer explains the word in the next phrase or sentence.	a follow-up sentence
Experience	Your own life experience suggests the meaning.	think: has this happened to me?
Knowledge of subject	General knowledge of the topic gives the meaning.	what you already know
Combination	Several clues are used together (the most common case).	

2. Paraphrasing (p. 17–18)

Paraphrasing means expressing a source's information **in your own words** while keeping the **original meaning**.

A good paraphrase…	A weak paraphrase…
keeps the original meaning uses different vocabulary where appropriate changes the sentence structure is clear and natural still acknowledges the source when required	changes only one or two words copies the original sentence pattern adds ideas that were not in the source changes the meaning

Six-step process

1. Read until you understand it → 2. Identify the essential meaning and key terms → 3. Look away from the original → 4. Rewrite the idea in a new sentence → 5. Compare the two versions → 6. Check that the meaning is accurate and the wording is different enough.

Remember: paraphrasing is **not** swapping every word for a synonym. Understand the idea, then say it naturally in a new way.

3. Author's Purpose (p. 44–56)

Ask: *Why did the author write this? What do they want me to think, feel, know or do?* Authors rarely state their purpose, so you work it out from clues.

	To ENTERTAIN	To INFORM	To PERSUADE
Aim	interest, amuse, entertain	explain; give new knowledge	change opinions or encourage action
Look for	humour (exaggeration, understatement); characters and events; creative, imaginative, dramatic language	facts, statistics, definitions; examples and explanations; objective, neutral language; little or no personal opinion	subjective language; a clear point of view or bias; appeals to reason, emotion or ethics; *must*, *need to*, *should*, *have to*; a call for change or action
Typical sources	novels, short stories, comics, humorous essays	textbooks, encyclopedias, journals, news articles	ads, speeches, editorials, political texts

General vs. specific purpose

- **General (primary) purpose**: entertain, inform or persuade.
- **Specific purpose**: adds the detail, e.g. *to inform readers that too much sun exposure may lead to skin cancer*.
- A text can have **several purposes**, but one is primary. **If persuasion drives the text, the primary purpose is usually to persuade.**

How to find it

- Check the **title, headings, introduction and conclusion**.
- Note the **source** (newspaper article = inform; editorial = persuade) and the **audience**.
- Identify the main idea and key details, then look at the **word choice**: neutral or meant to influence you?

Summarising (linked skill)

A summary restates the **main ideas in your own words**, in order of importance and objectively. Leave out minor details, trivia and repetition. Never write *I think*: it is always the **author** who thinks, argues or believes. Use who / what / where / when / why / how to pick out the key details.

4. Topics, Main Ideas & Supporting Details (p. 57–76)

Term	What it is	Ask yourself
Topic	The subject, usually one word or phrase (often the most repeated noun). It works like a title, neither **too general** nor **too specific**.	*What / who is this about?*
Main idea	The author's key point about the topic. It is a **general** statement, one sentence long.	*What does the author want me to know about the topic?*
Major supporting details (MSD)	Directly support the main idea with facts, examples, reasons or statistics.	who, what, where, when, why, how?
Minor supporting details (msd)	Support the major details with more specific examples or evidence.	

Stated vs. implied main ideas

- **Stated**: one sentence in the paragraph expresses it (usually the first or last sentence, but not always).
- **Implied**: no single sentence states it, so **you** write one general sentence that unites the details.
- Supporting details are **always stated**. Some descriptive or background paragraphs have no main idea at all.

Where the main idea sits (paragraph diagrams)

Position	Shape	Pattern
First sentence	Inverted triangle	main idea, then details
Last sentence	Triangle	details lead to the main idea as a conclusion
Middle	Diamond	details, main idea, more details
First and last	Hourglass	main idea, details, main idea restated
Implied (none stated)	Rectangle	all sentences together build the idea

Academic paragraph structure (writing)

Topic sentence (main idea) → **Supporting detail 1** + minor detail → **Supporting detail 2** + minor detail → **Concluding sentence** (returns to the main idea and gives closure). **Every sentence must relate to the main idea.**

5. Transition Words & Patterns of Organisation (p. 82–99)

Transition words link ideas and show how they relate (*trans* = across). They also signal the writer's **pattern of organisation**: how the supporting details are arranged in **expository** writing.

Pattern	What the writer does	Signal words
Example	gives illustrations to make a point clearer	for example, for instance, such as, to illustrate, in particular, specifically
Cause & effect	explains why something happens and its results	because, since, due to, as a result, therefore, thus, hence, consequently, lead to
Steps in a process	actions in a fixed order (how to do something)	first, second, next, then, after, at this stage, finally
Comparison	shows similarities	similarly, likewise, both, just as, like, in comparison
Contrast	shows differences	however, but, although, in contrast, on the other hand, unlike, instead, yet, whereas
Definition	explains what a term means	means, is defined as, refers to, is called, derives / originates from
Classification / division	sorts things into groups or categories	classify, categorise, divide, group, types, kinds, break down
Chronological order	events in time order	dates, times, before, during, after, then, later, currently, finally

Pattern	What the writer does	Signal words
Listing / enumeration	items with no necessary order	first, second, also, in addition; colons, bullets, numbers, letters
Spatial order	describes location or arrangement	above, below, beside, next to, left, right, near, beyond

Other transition groups

Addition: also, moreover, furthermore, in addition, besides · **Emphasis**: certainly, truly, without a doubt, to emphasize · **Concession**: although, even though, despite, in spite of · **Summary / conclusion**: in conclusion, in short, overall, to sum up, thus.

Identifying the pattern: look for repeated signal words and ask how the details relate to the main idea. Texts often combine patterns, so name the **dominant** one. The same word can fit several groups (e.g. *first*), so **meaning in context** matters more than any single word.

6. Modes of Discourse (p. 100–107)

A **mode of discourse** is the main way a writer presents and develops ideas. Ask: *Is the writer telling a story, painting a picture, explaining, or trying to convince me?*

Mode	What it does	Key features	Usual purpose
Narration	tells a story or experience (true or imaginary)	chronological order; characters and setting; may include dialogue; informal speech and contractions	entertain
Description	creates a verbal picture of a person, place, object or feeling	vivid details; appeals to the five senses; rich adjectives; imagery, similes, metaphors	entertain or inform
Exposition	explains or gives information	factual; examples, definitions, comparisons, statistics; objective, neutral tone; formal; no clear personal position	inform
Persuasion	argues a position and tries to influence the reader	clear point of view; logical or emotional arguments; facts, research, expert opinion; subjective language; *should*, *must*, *need to*	persuade

Combinations: Narration + Description → primary mode is **Narration**. Exposition + Persuasion, or Narration + Persuasion → primary mode is **Persuasion** (if persuasion is present, it is usually the primary mode).

7. Vocabulary: Prefixes (p. 144–151)

Prefixes of negation and reversal

A **prefix** is a letter group added before a root word that changes its meaning: **a-, counter-, de-, dis-, non-, il-, im-, in-, ir-, un-**. Negation: *approve* → *disapprove*. Reversal: *arm* → *disarm*.

Spelling rule	Examples from the worksheet
il- before words starting with **l**	illogical, illegitimate
im- before **b, m, p**	improper, impolite, immovable, impossible
ir- before **r**	irregular, irrational
others	inactive, inexpensive, indecisive, nonviolent, deregulate, unpleasant

Number prefixes

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
uni-, mono-	bi-, di-, du(o)-	tri-	quad-, tetra-	pent-, quint-	hex-, sex-	hept-, sept-	oct-	nov-, non-	dec-

ped / pod = foot

Key words

biped: animal with 2 feet **quadruped**: animal with 4 feet **tripod**: 3-legged stand (camera) **unicorn**: mythical 1-horned animal **unison**: same note / words at the same time **monologue**: one person speaking alone **unilateral**: one-sided (decision)	**bilateral**: two-sided (agreement) **dual**: two of a kind (dual citizenship) **duel**: formal fight between 2 people **duet**: music for 2 performers **duo**: a pair of performers **trio / quartet**: group of 3 / 4 **quintuplets...septuplets**: 5–7 babies born at once	**hexagon / octagon**: 6- / 8-sided shape **decade**: 10 years **biathlon / triathlon**: 2 / 3 events **heptathlon**: 7 events (women) **decathlon**: 10 events **sexa- / septua- / octo- / nonagenarian**: person in their 60s / 70s / 80s / 90s